

2.1.4 Evidence Collection

Description

Mission: Determine who invented the computer.

Directions: Use this notecatcher to document your findings as you go. For easy access, open this activity in a new tab!

Solution Code

default.txt

Charles Babbage

1. Time Period: Early 1800s
2. What did the term 'computer' mean? Babbage used terms like "machine" and "engine." He thought of computers as machines that could calculate complex math without making mistakes.
3. Main contribution: Babbage designed the world's first automatic computing machine. The Analytical Engine is potentially the world's first programmable computer - although it was never actually made.

Ada Lovelace

1. Time Period: 1840s, same time as Babbage
2. What did the term 'computer' mean? Lovelace thought of a computer as an automatic machine that could do complex math - she believed that Babbage's Analytical Engine could also be programmed to complete tasks outside of just math.
3. Main contribution: Lovelace wrote the first computer program/algorithm for Babbage's Analytical Engine

Alan Turing:

1. Time Period: 1912 - 1954
2. What did the term 'computer' mean? A computer was a machine that could hold things in memory and be programmed by using algorithms
3. Main contribution: invented modern computing, wrote the paper that became the foundation of computer science

Mauchly and Eckert

1. Time Period: 1940s
2. What did the term 'computer' mean? A machine that could calculate complex mathematical equations
3. Main contribution: created the first electronic computer

ENIAC Programmers

1. Time Period: 1940s
2. What did the term 'computer' mean? A machine that could calculate complex

mathematical equations

3. Main contribution: first programmers - programmed the ENIAC

Grace Hopper

1. Time Period: 1960s

2. What did the term 'computer' mean? A digital machine that you could program - although writing a program was very difficult

3. Main contribution: developed the first compiler and the COBOL programming language - made writing programs much easier

Mark Dean

1. Time Period: 1970s - current

2. What did the term 'computer' mean? A device that could be programmed and used by all people

3. Main contribution: ISA systems bus that enabled peripherals to be connected to computers; color PC monitor, first gigahertz processing chip

Bonus Exhibit

1. Who is missing from this picture? Mark Dean (black) and all of the women are missing.

2. What questions do you have about this image? Who chooses what people appear? Why were these people chosen over others?

3. Why do you think some are included while others are not? Women and people of color have traditionally been left out of the history books while white men tend to be front and center. This has to do with historical context - women and people of color were not given as many opportunities or viewed as equals at the time.